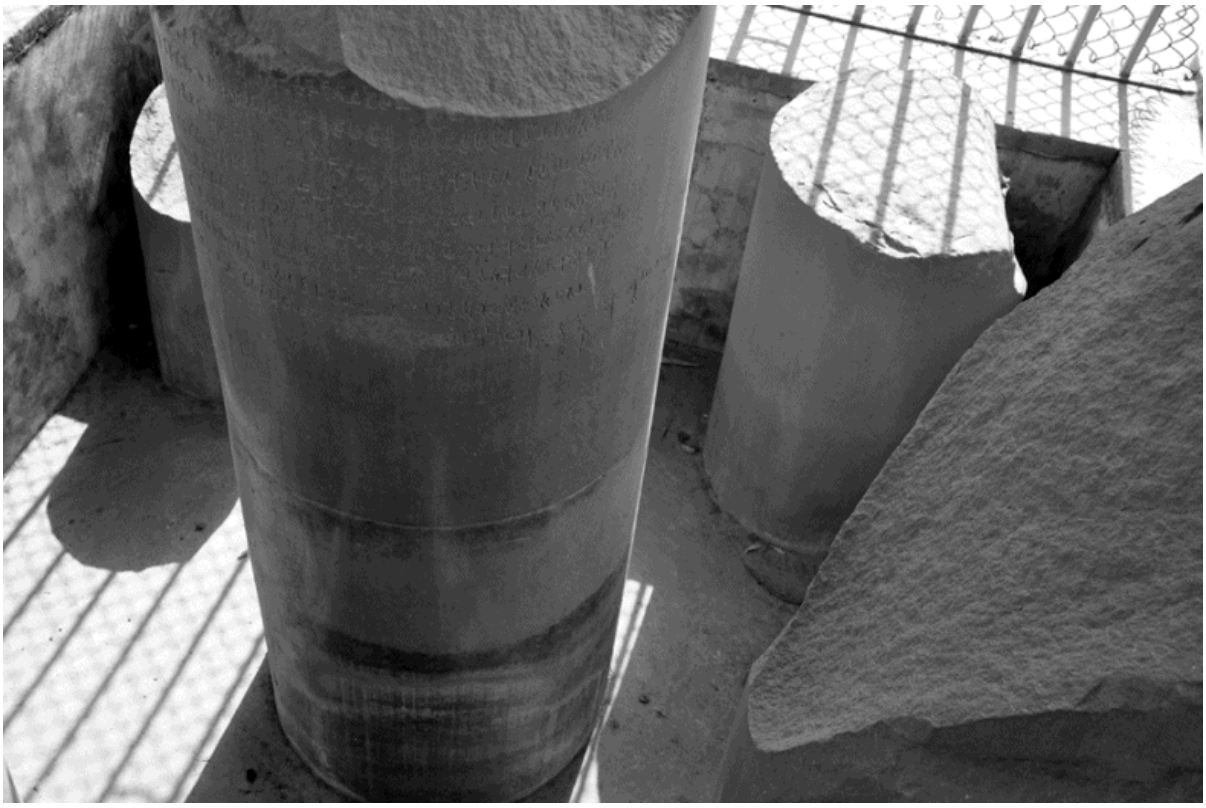


Fig.10.13: The broken Sarnath pillar with the edict inscribed on it

At Sarnath there was a large and influential Buddhist establishment, so the exhortation was logical. Shorter versions of this edict appear on monoliths at Kaushambi and Sanchi. At Kaushambi this was inscribed below after a much longer message issued twenty-six years into Ashoka's reign, making it a late work. The pillar on which the Kaushambi edict was inscribed stands today inside the Fort area of Allahabad, but since it mentions the mahamatras of Kaushambi, that may well have been its original location. Kaushambi, one of the six great cities of the Buddha's time, had several monasteries built by merchants for the Buddha.[61] Of these the Ghositarama, built by the merchant Ghosita, was identified with the structure of a big vihara in the north-eastern corner of the city. That Ashoka put up a schism edict at the city suggests that it was an important establishment of the Sangha. It was also one which in the time of the Buddha was known to have witnessed monastic disputes.[62]